

Activism in the Digital Age

Rutgers University, Department of Political Science

Spring 2026, March 10 to May 4

1.5 Credits, Fully Asynchronous, 7 Weeks

Instructor: Pin Lu, pin.lu@rutgers.edu

Office Hours: Fridays 2:00 to 4:00 pm on Zoom, and by appointment. The meeting link is posted on Canvas.

Course Description

Digital technologies have reorganized the conditions under which people mobilize. Social movements now form through platforms that lower the cost of coordination and place activists inside infrastructures owned and governed by corporations. This course examines that reorganization with concepts drawn from comparative politics and social movement studies, among them collective and connective action, repertoires of contention, and digital repression. A second set comes from research on digital communication, including platform affordances, networked publics, and the digital divide.

The course follows digital activism across arenas. Platforms set the technical and commercial conditions for coordination, while hashtag campaigns and street mobilization feed into each other in ways that vary by setting. Visibility is distributed unevenly, so gender, race, disability, and class bear on whose claims circulate. States and counter-movements answer with censorship, surveillance, disinformation, and mobilization of their own.

Cases are drawn from both democratic and authoritarian countries, so that general claims about digital technology can be tested against variation in regime type, movement resources, and issue. The course closes on the empirical record of what digital mobilization has achieved and on the critiques that record has generated.

Learning Objectives

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

- Understand how digital technologies change the organization, reach, and vulnerability of collective action.
- Evaluate claims about what digital mobilization achieves against the evidence behind them.
- Apply frameworks from the literature to an original case study of a movement in practice.

Course Format

The course runs fully asynchronously on Canvas, and students complete each week on their own schedule within the posted deadlines. Each week carries four components.

Video Lectures

Recorded lectures run 20 to 25 minutes each week, divided into two or three segments. They set out the analytical frame for the week and introduce cases, debates, and recent developments that go beyond the assigned readings. Students watch the lectures before writing the weekly response.

Readings on Perusall

Two readings are assigned each week. Students choose one, read it closely, and post at least five substantive annotations on Perusall, in the form of comments, questions, or replies to classmates. Guidance on Perusall is posted on Canvas in Week 1.

Weekly Response

Each weekly lecture raises questions at several points along the way. The response answers them in 300 to 500 words, applying the concepts of the week to a single digital activism case, selected by the student in Week 1 and carried through the term. The responses accumulate into the material for the final project.

Final Project

The weekly responses are integrated into one case study and presented in a recorded video of about 15 minutes. Rubrics for every component are posted on Canvas.

Assessment

Component	Description	Deadline	Weight
Self-introduction and survey	Short Canvas post and entry survey	March 16	5%
Perusall annotations	Five substantive annotations each week, best five of seven weeks	Fridays, 11:59 pm	35%
Weekly responses	300 to 500 words each week, best five of seven weeks	Mondays, 11:59 pm	30%
Final project	Integrated case study, recorded video of about 15 minutes	May 15, 11:59 pm	30%

Annotations and responses are each graded on the best five of seven weeks, which allows two weeks off in each category. The two allowances apply to different weeks, so every week of the course carries at least one submission.

Weekly Schedule

Week 1 (March 10 to 16). Definitions and Boundaries of Digital Activism

- Boundaries between online and offline activism
- Typologies from clicktivism to hacktivism
- Changes in the cost, scale, and speed of protest
- Media environments and collective action

Readings, choose one

Earl, Jennifer, Katrina Kimport, Greg Prieto, Carly Rush, and Kimberly Reynoso. 2010. "Changing the World One Webpage at a Time: Conceptualizing and Explaining Internet Activism." *Mobilization: An International Quarterly* 15(4): 425–446.

or

Bimber, Bruce, Andrew J. Flanagin, and Cynthia Stohl. 2005. "Reconceptualizing Collective Action in the Contemporary Media Environment." *Communication Theory* 15(4): 365–388.

Spring Recess (March 17 to 23). *No assignments are due this week.*

Week 2 (March 24 to 30). Platform Affordances and Connective Action

- Platform design and user practice

- Personal action frames and collective identity
- Coordination without formal organizations
- Moderation and the governance of speech

Readings, choose one

Bennett, W. Lance, and Alexandra Segerberg. 2012. "The Logic of Connective Action: Digital Media and the Personalization of Contentious Politics." *Information, Communication & Society* 15(5): 739–768.

or

Bossetta, Michael. 2018. "The Digital Architectures of Social Media: Comparing Political Campaigning on Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, and Snapchat in the 2016 U.S. Election." *Journalism & Mass Communication Quarterly* 95(2): 471–496.

Week 3 (March 31 to April 6). Online and Offline Dynamics of Protest

- Online mobilization and street turnout
- Repertoires across digital and physical space
- Media attention and elite response
- Measuring protest with social media data

Readings, choose one

Tufekci, Zeynep, and Christopher Wilson. 2012. "Social Media and the Decision to Participate in Political Protest: Observations from Tahrir Square." *Journal of Communication* 62(2): 363–379.

or

Freelon, Deen, Charlton D. McIlwain, and Meredith D. Clark. 2018. "Quantifying the Power and Consequences of Social Media Protest." *New Media & Society* 20(3): 990–1011.

Week 4 (April 7 to 13). Identity, Visibility, and Voice

- Hashtag networks and gendered violence
- Disability activism and civic participation
- Networked counterpublics
- Online harassment across identity groups

Readings, choose one

Clark, Rosemary. 2016. "'Hope in a Hashtag': The Discursive Activism of #WhyIStayed." *Feminist Media Studies* 16(5): 788–804.

or

Mann, Benjamin W. 2018. "Rhetoric of Online Disability Activism: #CripTheVote and Civic Participation." *Communication Culture & Critique* 11(4): 604–621.

Week 5 (April 14 to 20). Disinformation and Counter-Mobilization

- Divergent online tactics of left and right
- Repertoires of disinformation and manipulation
- Exposure to opposing views and polarization

Readings, choose one

Freelon, Deen, Alice Marwick, and Daniel Kreiss. 2020. "False Equivalencies: Online Activism from Left to Right." *Science* 369(6508): 1197–1201.

or

Bail, Christopher A., Lisa P. Argyle, Taylor W. Brown, John P. Bumpus, Haohan Chen, M. B. Fallin Hunzaker, Jaemin Lee, Marcus Mann, Friedolin Merhout, and Alexander Volfovsky. 2018. "Exposure to Opposing Views on Social Media Can Increase Political Polarization." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 115(37): 9216–9221.

Week 6 (April 21 to 27). Surveillance, Censorship, and Digital Repression

- Selective censorship of collective expression
- Digital repression across regimes
- Infrastructure of online control
- Repression and subsequent mobilization

Readings, choose one

King, Gary, Jennifer Pan, and Margaret E. Roberts. 2013. "How Censorship in China Allows Government Criticism but Silences Collective Expression." *American Political Science Review* 107(2): 326–343.

or

Earl, Jennifer, Thomas V. Maher, and Jennifer Pan. 2022. "The Digital Repression of Social Movements, Protest, and Activism: A Synthetic Review." *Science Advances* 8(10): eabl8198.

Week 7 (April 28 to May 4). Inequality, Algorithms, and the Critique of Digital Activism

- Class and cost in online participation
- Algorithms and the form of collective action
- Weak ties and high-risk activism

Readings, choose one

Schradie, Jen. 2018. "The Digital Activism Gap: How Class and Costs Shape Online Collective Action." *Social Problems* 65(1): 51–74.

or

Milan, Stefania. 2015. "When Algorithms Shape Collective Action: Social Media and the Dynamics of Cloud Protest." *Social Media + Society* 1(2): 2056305115622481.

Supplementary Materials

The following are optional. Each connects to the week noted, and its argument is covered in the recorded lectures.

Week 2. Nagy, Peter, and Gina Neff. 2015. "Imagined Affordance: Reconstructing a Keyword for Communication Theory." *Social Media + Society* 1(2): 2056305115603385.

Week 5. Marwick, Alice, and Rebecca Lewis. 2017. *Media Manipulation and Disinformation Online*. New York: Data & Society Research Institute.

Week 5. Wardle, Claire, and Hossein Derakhshan. 2017. *Information Disorder: Toward an Interdisciplinary Framework for Research and Policymaking*. Strasbourg: Council of Europe.

Week 7. Gladwell, Malcolm. 2010. "Small Change: Why the Revolution Will Not Be Tweeted." *The New Yorker*, October 4.

Final Project

The final project integrates the weekly responses into a single case study of one digital activism campaign and presents it as a recorded video of about 15 minutes. The case study describes the campaign, situates it within

the concepts of the course, and assesses what the campaign achieved. The project is due May 15 at 11:59 pm. The rubric is posted on Canvas in Week 4.

Course Policies

Deadlines and Late Work

Perusall annotations are due Fridays at 11:59 pm, which leaves time for peer interaction before the response deadline. Weekly responses are due the following Monday at 11:59 pm. Late submissions lose 10 percent per day. Students who anticipate difficulty meeting a deadline should contact the instructor before it passes to discuss an extension.

Artificial Intelligence

Students may use AI tools to brainstorm ideas and to check grammar and clarity of expression. The analytical argument, the selection of the case, and the interpretive work are the student's own. Students who use AI beyond grammar checking include a brief note at the end of the submission describing that use. Submission of AI-generated analysis as one's own work is handled under the University policy on academic integrity.

Academic Integrity

All work complies with the Rutgers University Academic Integrity Policy. Plagiarism, fabrication, and unauthorized collaboration are referred to the Office of Student Conduct.

Accessibility

Students seeking accommodation should follow the registration procedure of the Office of Disability Services at ods.rutgers.edu. The instructor will implement approved accommodations on receipt of the letter of accommodation.

Contacting the Instructor

Email receives a reply within 24 hours on weekdays. Office hours run on Zoom every Friday, and additional times are available by appointment.

This syllabus may change as the course proceeds, with any change announced on Canvas.